

IT PROJECT MANAGEMENT

TOPIC 10

PROJECT PLANNING (PROJECT COMMUNICATION & STAKEHOLDER MANAGEMENT)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

a. Understand the importance of good communications on projects and the need to develop soft skills, especially for IT project managers and their teams
b. Explain the project communication Management processes
c. Review key concepts related to communications
d. Explain the elements of **planning** project communications and how to create a communications management plan
e. Understand the importance of project stakeholder management throughout the life of a project
f. Discuss the process of identifying stakeholders, how to create a stakeholder register, and how to perform a stakeholder analysis
g. Describe the contents of a stakeholder management plan

PROJECT COMMUNICATION MANAGEMENT

IMPORTANCE OF GOOD COMMUNICATIONS

- The greatest threat to many projects is a failure to communicate
- Our culture does not portray IT professionals as being good communicators
- Research shows that IT professionals must be able to communicate effectively to succeed in their positions
- Strong verbal and non-technical skills are a key factor in career advancement for IT professionals

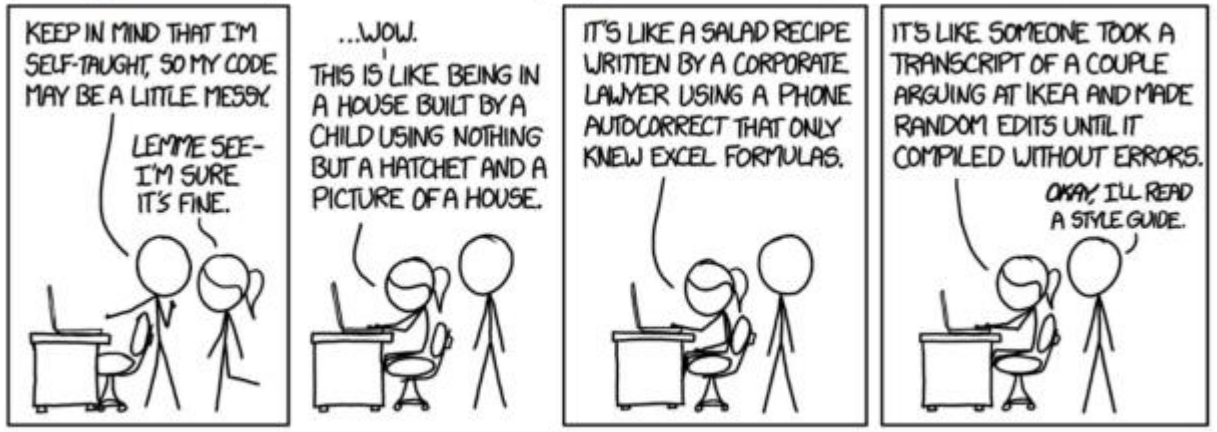


Figure 6-13. Code quality (www.xkcd.com)

IMPORTANCE OF GOOD COMMUNICATIONS

- Many experts agree that the greatest threat to the success of any project is a failure to communicate.
  - It is often said that project managers spend 90% of time communicating.
    - Yet many project managers fail to take the time to plan for it.
    - Even though having a communications management plan does not guarantee that all project communications will flow smoothly, it certainly helps.
  - Project communications management involves generating, collecting, disseminating, and storing project information.
  - Key outputs produced for many projects, include a communications management plan and a project website

PLANNING COMMUNICATIONS MANAGEMENT

- Every project should include some type of **communications management** plan, a document that guides project communications
  - The communications management plan **varies** with the needs of the project, but some type of written plan should always be prepared
  - For **small projects**, the communications management plan can be part of the team contract
  - For **large projects**, it should be a separate document

- The plan should describe who will provide and receive data, when, and how the information will be presented.
- Stakeholders may change depending on the project phase, so the plan must be updated as needed.

COMMUNICATIONS MANAGEMENT PLAN CONTENTS

1. Stakeholder communications requirements
2. Information to be communicated, including format, content, and level of detail
3. Who will receive the information and who will produce it
4. Suggested methods or technologies for conveying the information
5. Frequency of communication
6. Escalation procedures for resolving issues
7. Revision procedures for updating the communications management plan
8. A glossary of common terminology

Stakeholders	Document Name	Document Format	Contact Person	Due
Customer management	Monthly status report	Hard copy and meeting	Tina Erndt, Tom Silve	First of month
Customer business staff	Monthly status report	Hard copy	Julie Grant, Sergey Cristobal	First of month
Customer technical staff	Monthly status report	E-mail	Li Chau, Nancy Michaels	First of month
Internal management	Monthly status report	Hard copy and meeting	Bob Thomson	First of month
Internal business and technical staff	Monthly status report	Intranet	Angie Liu	First of month
Training subcontractor	Training plan	Hard copy	Jonathan Kraus	November 1
Software subcontractor	Software implementation plan	E-mail	Najwa Gates	June 1

Sample Stakeholder Analysis for Project Communications

SAMPLE COMMUNICATIONS MANAGEMENT PLAN

Communication Management Plan Version 1.0
August 28

Project Name: Just-In-Time Training Project

1. Stakeholder Communications Requirements

Because this project involves many people from all over the company as well as outside suppliers, the project team will use surveys, interviews, checklists, and other tools and techniques to determine the communications requirements for various stakeholders. Employees will have specific communications needs in that several training programs are being totally changed, and they will likely be uncomfortable with those changes. Suppliers will have communications needs to ensure that they are developing courses that will meet our organization's requirements. Internal experts providing content will have communications needs related to providing useful information and products.

2. Communications Summary

The following table summarizes various stakeholders, communications required, the delivery method or format of the communications, who will produce the communications, and when it will be distributed or the frequency of distribution. All communications produced will be archived and available on the project website. As more communications items are defined, they will be added to this list. The project team will use various templates and checklists to enhance communications. The team will also be careful to use the appropriate medium (that is, face-to-face meeting, phone, e-mail, website, and so on) and follow corporate guidelines for effective communications. Note the comments/guidelines as well.

Stakeholders	Communications Name	Delivery Method/Format	Producer	Due Date/ Frequency
Project steering committee	Weekly status report	Hard copy and short meeting	Kristin Maur	Wed. mornings at 9 AM
Sponsor and champion	Monthly status report	Hard copy and short meeting	Kristin Maur	First Thursday of month at 10 AM

Affected employees	Project announcement	Memo, e-mail, intranet site, and announcement at department meetings	Lucy C. and Mike S.	July 1
Project team	Weekly status report	Short meeting	All team	Tues.at 2 PM.
Project team	Daily report to PM	Verbal – 1-5 minutes	All team	Each morning by 10:00

3. Guidelines

- Make sure people understand your communications. Use common sense techniques to check comprehension, such as having them explain what you mean in their own words. Don't overuse/misuse e-mail or other technologies. Short meetings or phone calls can be very effective.
- Use templates as much as possible for written project communications. The project website includes a link to all project-related templates.
- Use the titles and dates of documents in e-mail headings and have recipients acknowledge receipt.
- Prepare and post meeting minutes within 24 hours of a meeting.
- Use checklists where appropriate, such as reviewing product requirements and conducting interviews.
- Use corporate facilitators for important meetings, such as kickoff meetings and supplier negotiations.

4. Escalation Procedures for Resolving Issues

Issues should be resolved at the lowest level possible. When they cannot be resolved, affected parties should alert their immediate supervisors of the issues. If it is critical to the project or extremely time-sensitive, the issue should be brought directly to the project manager. If the project manager cannot resolve an issue, he or she should bring it to the project steering committee or appropriate senior management, as required. Issue escalation steps should time-boxed to ensure quick resolution, perhaps in hours.

5. Revision Procedures for this Document

Revisions to this plan will be approved by the project manager. The revision number and date will be clearly marked at the top of the document.

6. Glossary of Common Terminology

actual cost — the total direct and indirect costs incurred in accomplishing work on an activity during a given period.

baseline — the original project plan plus approved changes.

Etc.

PROJECT WEBSITES

- Many project teams have started posting all or part of their project information to project websites.
  - Project websites provide a centralized way of delivering project documents and other communications.
  - Note that some organizations use a different type of repository to store information, such as a SharePoint site.
- Some teams also create **blogs**—easy-to-use journals on the Web that allow users to write entries, create links, and upload pictures, while allowing readers to post comments to entries.
  - Project teams can develop project websites using tools such as Wix, Google sites, or WordPress; project management software, if available; or a combination of the two approaches.
- Part of the website might be open to outside users, whereas other parts might be accessible only by certain stakeholders.
- Different levels of access would also be provided using the CRUD code: The user can Create, Read, Update, and/or Delete. It is important to decide if and how to use a project website to help meet project communications requirements.
- Some organizations also create quad charts as part of their project websites where the four quadrants show a project summary, financials, schedules, and issues.



Figure 6-15. Sample project website

AGILE COMMUNICATIONS PLANNING

- Instead of documenting how project teams will communicate, the Scrum framework includes specific events where a lot of communications takes place.
- As specified in The Scrum Guide (2020), “The Sprint is a container for all other events. … Events are used in Scrum to create regularity and to minimize the need for meetings not defined in Scrum.
- Optimally, all events are held at the same time and place to reduce complexity.

SAMPLE AGILE EVENTS TO AID IN COMMUNICATIONS

- Debra and her three Scrum teams did follow *The Scrum Guide* in terms of practicing the following events:
  - **Sprints**: The GCHC project had fixed length sprints of one month to create consistency. Each sprint had a clear sprint goal. For example, the incentives team's first sprint goal was to plan for a successful hiring days event and draft important policies for hiring and retention. The education team's sprint goal was to develop 2 courses to attract potential new hires and thoroughly research good education partners for additional educational opportunities for current and future workers.
  - **Sprint planning**: Each sprint started with a sprint planning meeting that lasted 8 hours or less. Topics discussed included the value of the sprint, what could be done during the sprint, and how the work would be done.
  - **Daily Scrum**: These 15-minute or less meetings focused on inspecting progress toward meeting the sprint goal, adapting the sprint backlog as needed, and adjusting the work for the next day. They improved communications by identifying impediments, promoting quick decision-making, and eliminating the need for other meetings.
  - **Sprint review**: In this 4-hour or less meeting the team presented the results of their work to key stakeholders and held a working session to inspect the outcome of the sprint and determine future adaptations.

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  - **Sprint review**: In this 4-hour or less meeting the team presented the results of their work to key stakeholders and held a working session to inspect the outcome of the sprint and determine future adaptations.
  - **Sprint retrospective**: The purpose of this 3-hour or less meeting with team members only was to plan ways to increase quality and effectiveness. Team members discussed what went well, what problems they encountered, and how those problems were (or were not) solved.

PROJECT STAKEHOLDER MANAGEMENT

PROJECT STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT PLANNING

- Project stakeholder engagement planning involves determining strategies to effectively engage stakeholders in project decisions and
  activities based on their needs, interests, and potential impact.
- The main output of this process is a stakeholder engagement plan.
- Stakeholders change as the project progresses, and stakeholder engagement planning should be updated based on those changes.
  - The staffing management plan shows when project team members join or leave the project.
  - The stakeholder engagement plan, the communications management plan, and the resource management plan should be in agreement with each other.
- It is also important for organizations to address larger cultural changes that may occur due to projects.
  - For example, the Just-InTime Training project ended the current company training.
  - Some employees might be upset over that decision. The GCHC project planned to change hiring and retention policies while also changing educational opportunities for both existing and potential workers. The impact of these new policies educational opportunities would definitely impact many people.

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT PLANS

- After identifying and analyzing stakeholders, the project manager and team should develop a stakeholder engagement plan to guide them in effectively engaging stakeholders to make sure good decisions are made throughout the life of the project.
  - This plan may be formal or informal, based on the needs of the project.
- A stakeholder engagement plan can include the following:
  - Current and desired engagement levels of key stakeholders
  - Scope and impact of change to stakeholders
  - Identified interrelationships between stakeholders and potential overlap
  - Potential management strategies for each stakeholder classification
  - Methods for updating the stakeholder management plan

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT PLAN

- Because a stakeholder engagement plan often includes sensitive information, it should not be part of the official project documents that are normally available for all stakeholders to review.
  - Often only project managers and a few other team members prepare the stakeholder engagement plan. In many cases, parts of the plan are not even written down, and if they are, distribution is strictly limited.

Name	Power/ Interest	Current/desired engagement	Potential Management Strategies
Mike Sundby	High/high	Supportive/ Supportive	Mike is very outgoing and visionary. Great traits for a project champion. He is concerned about financials and has an MBA. Manage closely and ask for his advice as needed. Schedule short face-to-face meetings as needed.
Lucy Camerena	High/high	Leading/ Leading	Lucy has a Ph.D. in education and knows training at this company. She is very professional and easy to work with, but she can stretch out conversations. Make sure she reviews important work before showing it to other managers.
Ron Ryan	Low/ medium	Resistant/ Supportive	Ron led the Phase I project and is upset that he was not asked to lead this Phase II project. He's been with the company over 20 years and can be a good resource, but he could also sabotage the project. Ask Lucy to talk to him to avoid problems. Perhaps give him a small consulting role on the project.

AGILE STAKEHOLDER PLANNING

- As stated in the previous section, the **sprint review meetings allow key stakeholders** to inspect the outcomes of each sprint and determine future adaptations.
- Agile project teams also discuss any impediments they are facing or could face in their **daily Scrum meetings**.
- The Scrum master or project manager works with the appropriate people to remove the impediments.
- Teams should also ensure that **key stakeholders participate in the sprint reviews**, develop acceptance criteria, and determine the Definition of Done for each increment.
- The information radiators provide visibility into work progress for all interested stakeholders

SUMMARY

- Planning outputs related to communications management include a communications management plan and project website.
- Planning outputs related to stakeholder management include a stakeholder engagement plan